

How to See a Person

What Is Left When Usefulness Is Taken Away



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Before You Start

◆ What This Book Is Doing

In one line:

How to see a person with usefulness taken away.

It does not argue that a person has worth. An argument can be answered, and an argument written so that it cannot be answered is where a reader stops thinking. So this book took another road. It goes to the places where usefulness really does fall to zero and watches what people do there. What people do cannot be argued with. It is simply there.

◆ Five Parts

Part	What it looks at
One · When the Counting Started	The day a number got attached to a person, and what numbers do
Two · Take It Away and Look	Four places where usefulness is zero. No outside material in this part
Three · So How Do You Look	Four things to do
Four · Between Two People	Where those four fail hardest — home, work, the street
Five · After the Machines	Where competing on usefulness is a contest already decided

◆ Two Things Are Attached to Every Chapter

One is "Today." Every chapter has one, except the last. Read only, and this book becomes a sermon. Do

them, and it becomes a book. All sixteen are small. Not one of them takes more than a day.

One is a place left unresolved. Every chapter has one of those too. A question I do not have an answer to, written down as it is. It is not an oversight. If I could have written seventeen chapters that close cleanly, that would have been a different book.

◆ How the Facts Are Handled

Every chapter ends with a section called **Where This Chapter Comes From**. Two things go in it: what was checked, and what was cut because it could not be.

Books rarely print the second, and the second is more useful. In some chapters what was cut runs longer than what was kept. The level of checking is written down too. The checking in this book is public sources cross-read against one another. It is not primary sources. Where an original could not be opened, it says so.

Nothing was softened. When something could not be confirmed, it was cut whole rather than hedged. A hedged sentence gets read as a fact.

◆ There Is No Closing Chapter

Said here in advance. **This book has no closing chapter.** The last chapter ends on a question and nothing is written after it.

That is not a mistake. Anything put in that space turns into a sermon from the first line. Stopping there is the last thing this book can do.

Opening

◆ Opening

I started to write that a person has worth, and stopped.

I had the sentence down on paper and sat looking at it for a long time. It is not a false sentence. But it cannot be argued with, and a person stops thinking in front of a sentence that cannot be argued with. Nice, they think, and turn the page. Fill a book with sentences like that and it reads well and leaves nothing behind.

So I changed roads. I decided not to argue.

Instead I went to **the places where usefulness really does fall to zero**. Someone who cannot do anything yet. Someone stopped for a while. Someone handing back, one at a time, what they used to be able to do.

Someone skilled with nowhere left to use it. In those four places there is nothing to weigh and nothing to count. And yet people there do something.

That is what I decided to watch. What people do cannot be argued with. It is simply there.

Watching turned up something stronger. **What people do in those four places resembles itself.** Nobody taught them and they did not agree among themselves, and still it resembles itself, and write that resemblance down and you have things to do. Part Three of this book is that.

It would seem, then, that we could start at Part Two. There is one thing before it. If you do not know why we came to measure people so constantly, Part Two reads as a collection of sad stories. So Part One goes first. Three chapters, and the first one opens with a man writing in his diary in 1785.

Part One • When the Counting Started

Measuring people is not something that started yesterday. That has to be looked at first.

Three chapters. The first looks at the place where a number got attached to a person. The second looks at why it was that number and not another, and the third looks at what gets folded inward when the number is written onto a single sheet of paper.

This part was not written to blame counting. Counting exists in order to get work done and it mostly does its job extremely well. It is also true that the people nobody counts are the ones who live hardest.

So what is being looked for here is not a culprit. It is **when, and what, began to be counted.** Knowing that is different from not knowing it. Not knowing it, a person starts to think the numbers attached to them are them.

1 • The Day I Got a Number

◆ Autumn 1785, a Diary

At a college in America the president is examining the graduating class. There are fifty-eight of them. He calls them up one at a time, asks, listens, and when it is over he opens his diary and writes down how the day went. What he writes is four words. Twenty are the best, sixteen are second best, twelve are below, ten are worse. It is in Latin.

Fifty-eight people have become four lumps. It is said to be nearly the first recorded grading in American education.

◆ Only the Bottom Word Is Different

Look at those four words once more. Three of them say what a person is. Best, second best, below. They may sting depending on how you hear them, but at least they are statements about the person.

Only the bottom one is different. That word is a comparative. It means *worse*.

So the name attached to those ten does not tell you what sort of people they were. **It tells you who they are worse than.** It is a name that does not exist without the forty-eight ahead of them, and if those forty-eight improve, the ten get worse without moving.

What this book is trying to say is already inside four Latin words from 1785. I sat looking at it for a long while when I found it: one line of a diary from three centuries ago has the same shape as the review form in use at work right now.

◆ We Know That Word

I cannot read the name in that bottom box as a distant old story. The school system I grew up in has that name in it, unchanged.

There is a box called a grade band. That box is not decided by what I did or how much of it. It is decided by how many people are ahead of me. So I can study exactly as I studied last year, get exactly the score I got last year, and drop a box, because the people around me did better. And I can rise a box having done nothing at all.

Students know this without being told. After an exam, the first question is often not what you got. It is what the average was. They already know that their own score does not tell them their own box.

This is what the Latin word was doing in 1785. The system translated it and has been using it ever since.

◆ Fifty-Two Years

In 1837 that same college turned those four words into numbers. Four at the top, descending from there. There are historians who trace the grade point average now in use back to it.

It took fifty-two years. What changed in between was not people. It was the way of writing it down.

Written as words, it is hard to say which of three people is ahead. How far apart best and second best are is not carried in the words. Written as numbers, it is carried. A 4.0 and a 3.7 are 0.3 apart, and with that 0.3 you can stand two people in a line. From the moment subtraction works, people queue.

In my second year of middle school I was number 39. Numbers were handed out in order of height. There were five people behind me, and those five were big, and they were the ones who played sports.

So that number had nothing to do with anything I had done. Studying harder would not make me 38,

and doing nothing at all would not make me 40. The number was given to my height and I came along with it.

And looking at the five behind me I understood one more thing. **If those five had not been in that class, I would have been last.** My height is the same and the number is different. My number was not decided by me alone.

◆ Attach a Number and Comparison Follows by Itself

It is not that the people handing out numbers mean any harm. Numbers exist to get work done, and someone who has to deal with fifty-eight people needs them. But there is one thing numbers do that nobody asked them to do. Numbers compare themselves to each other. Set 3 beside 7 and a distance appears between them, and once there is a distance, which one is ahead comes out without being asked. That is the nature of numbers.

So a person who receives a number receives two things. A mark that points at them, and a distance to the person beside them. Nobody offered the second one. It arrives anyway.

◆ Without a Number Nobody Can Find Me

Here is where I could not come down on one side. Is being given a number necessarily bad?

Think about places with no numbers and it catches immediately. Without a number at a hospital my turn never comes. Without my name on a list at school nobody knows I am missing. People who are not counted are also not protected. In every country, the people nobody counts live hardest.

So numbers are used to stand people in a line and also to find people. The same device does both. I have not seen the line that separates the two uses, and this book is not the book that finds it; what is different is **knowing** that a number is attached to you

rather than not knowing. That difference is the part this book can do.

◆ Today

Write down every number attached to you today. All of them, as they come. Age, height, weight, salary, employee number, student number, scores, rank, credit score, step count, how many people follow you, how many unread messages. Write them out and two things show. There are more than you thought, and almost none of them is a number you chose.

◆ Where This Chapter Comes From

The 1785 diary is Ezra Stiles's, president of Yale. The line dividing fifty-eight students into four grades survives, and in 1837 Yale turned those grades into a four-point scale. It is a passage often cited in the history of education, and the bibliography that travels with it is Smallwood, *A Historical Study of*

Academic Marks in American Colleges (Harvard University Press, 1935).

I could open neither the diary nor Smallwood's book. This is public sources cross-read against one another. The four Latin words and the number fifty-eight come out the same in many places, but things that float around identically are not a source, and before publication someone should sit with the originals in a library.

No numbers were written into the section about the school system I grew up in. Which percentage falls in which band changes whenever the system changes, so writing it down would age it immediately, and only the structure was written down: that your box is set by how many people are ahead of you. That structure does not age.

One thing was left out. There is a far older system for sorting people into grades in East Asia, more than a thousand years earlier. Putting it in would turn this

chapter into a history of institutions, and then the name in the bottom box of those four words gets buried, and that one word is what this chapter is looking at.

The next chapter is about why it went that way. Seeing a person whole is hard, and when something is hard the easy thing next to it takes its place.

2 · The Whole Person Is Hard, Output Is Easy

◆ The Conclusion First

When the thing you meant to measure is hard, the easy thing standing next to it takes its place.

How much a student has grown is hard to measure and a test score is easy. How well a doctor saw a patient is hard to measure and how many minutes it took is easy, and how well a person does their work is hard to measure and how many cases they closed is easy. So we measure the easy one. It is not that the hard one gets abandoned. We measure the easy one while believing we are measuring the hard one. In chapter one a number got attached to a person; this chapter looks at why it was that number.

◆ A Sentence Written in 1976

Someone gave this thing a name. The year was 1976.

The more any quantitative social indicator is used for social decision-making, the more subject it will be to corruption pressures and the more apt it will be to distort and corrupt the social processes it is intended to monitor.

It reads as obvious, and there is one part of it that is not. **The reason an indicator corrupts is that it became important.** An indicator nobody uses does not corrupt. It starts corrupting the moment it starts being used. So this is not a problem you solve by choosing a better indicator, because if the one you chose is good enough to be widely used, the fact of being widely used is what breaks it.

◆ Four Hours

One country set a target: anyone arriving at an emergency department should be dealt with inside four hours. It is a good target. If someone waited eight hours in an emergency department, that needs fixing.

Things happened after the target existed.

People were admitted at three hours fifty-eight minutes. Whether admission was the right call became the second question. Ambulances were held outside the building, because a patient who has not yet *arrived* does not start the clock, and during counting periods, surgeries in other departments were postponed and staff were pulled across to the emergency department.

The numbers improved. What the numbers were meant to measure got worse.

◆ Counting Erasures

A different country, a different field. In 2009 a local newspaper found unexplained rises in that state's school test scores. For two schools the odds of rising that much were smaller than one in a billion. So the state went back to the answer sheets. What it counted was erasure marks.

It counted, classroom by classroom, how often a wrong answer had been erased and changed to a right one, and flagged any classroom more than three standard deviations above the state average for the same grade and subject. Class size was adjusted for.

This is the middle of the chapter. The score was easy to measure, so the score got changed. To catch that, measuring the score was no longer enough; **the marks left by changing the score** had to be measured.

Measure the easy thing, and to catch what that does you have to measure again.

◆ Why It Went That Way

In 2011 a special investigation in that state issued a report. It runs to about eight hundred pages. More than a hundred and seventy people were implicated, across forty-four schools. The report names one cause. Targets set higher than anyone could reach, and the humiliation of not reaching them. People who tried to report it were retaliated against, and the investigators described the atmosphere as fear and intimidation.

What happened after that is not in this chapter. Write down who ended up where and the sentence a reader remembers becomes that sentence, and that sentence covers what the chapter is trying to say, so this chapter looks as far as why the people in that position did what they did.

I once sat on an interview panel. A school was selecting people and I was on the asking side. What I wanted to see was integrity and diligence. I thought

nothing mattered more than those two in the person who would come, and I still think so.

What I actually looked at that day was ability and intelligence. The questions went that way and the boxes I was writing in were built that way. Ability and intelligence are reasonably visible in thirty minutes. I never managed to build a question that showed me integrity in thirty minutes.

I could not build it, so I did not ask; I did not ask, so I did not measure; and because I did not measure, integrity in that room may as well not have existed.

◆ The Two Are Not the Same Thing

Set those two cases side by side and they do different work.

The four-hour case is a target that bent **behavior**. The numbers were recorded honestly. People moved differently in order to make those numbers true.

The erasure case is a target that bent **the number itself**. There was no room to change the behavior, so the record was changed.

The second looks like the worse thing, and in this chapter the first is the more frightening one. Nobody wrote down anything false and the thing being measured was ruined anyway. There is no one to hold responsible. Everyone followed the rules.

◆ Is Measuring the Easy Thing Always Bad

This is where my own argument runs out.

Measuring the easy thing is useful. If fewer people waited eight hours after the emergency department started timing, that is something the number did.

There are many places where nothing changes unless it is measured, and if you measure nothing at all in the name of seeing people whole, the weakest person is pushed out first. It is the same shape as the end of chapter one.

So how far is a ruler still worth using? At what point does the ruler start eating the thing it was built to measure? I never saw the end of it. I drew the line several times while writing, and each time a counterexample followed the line out.

◆ In Short

What was meant to be measured	What actually gets measured
How much a student grew	Test scores
Whether the patient was seen well	How many minutes it took
Whether someone is good at the work	How many cases closed
Once the number stops being trusted	The marks left by changing the number

◆ Today

Write down, separately, **what you measure** and what you meant to measure. Fold a sheet in half: on the left what you actually count, on the right what you wanted in the first place.

If the two sides match, you work somewhere good. If they do not, look at how far apart they are. Far apart is the common case, and a person who knows the distance trusts the left-hand column less. That alone changes how they work.

◆ Where This Chapter Comes From

The 1976 sentence is Donald Campbell's and is commonly known by his name; the four-hour emergency target is a British case, and the 2009 scores and 2011 report concern schools in Atlanta, Georgia, in the United States.

I could not open any of the three originals. This is public sources cross-read against one another, and for the report I confirmed only that it runs to roughly

eight hundred pages. The erasure criteria — three standard deviations, adjusted for class size — are the spine of this chapter and should be read in the report itself before publication.

Two things were left out: the people prosecuted over it and how the trials went, and who held which post. They are vivid and they stick, which is why they are not here. It is not that they are untrue. They were cut to keep this chapter from becoming a book about school systems. This book cannot be that book.

The next chapter is about paper. To put a person on one sheet you have to fold them, and folding always sends something inward.

3 · Folding a Person Onto One Page

◆ If You Were Told to Write Yourself on One Page

Say you are handed a single sheet of paper. You have to write yourself onto it. One sheet, and the boxes are already decided.

What would you write? And once you had written it, what would not be there?

The second question is this chapter.

◆ 1940, Five Million Sheets

During a war, one country had every foreign national living on its soil fill out a single form. These were the fields on it.

Name · date of birth · place of birth · nationality ·
sex · marital status · race · height · weight · color
of hair · color of eyes

More than five million were collected.

I have not found anything that shows better what happens when one person goes onto one page. Five million people became those eleven boxes.

◆ Only Things You Cannot Choose Are on It

Look at the fields again and something catches. Almost all eleven are things the person could not choose. Nobody chose their hair color. Nor eye color, nor place of birth, nor race. Height is mostly not chosen, and weight is a little different, but what that box asks for is today's figure.

So what is not on that sheet? Nothing the person did. Nothing they knew how to do. Nothing about who

they lived with or what they cared for. Not one thing they chose. What the form wanted were the marks by which a person could be found again, and for that, the things that do not change and cannot be chosen are the most useful. The form did its job extremely well.

There is one thing my own resume has no box for. Purity. It is not that there is no room to write it. There is no box because writing it down would not make it believable. That is something you only know after time has passed.

In chapter two I wrote that I could not build a question that showed integrity in thirty minutes. The same thing shows up here as a missing box. What will not go onto one page and what will not show in thirty minutes are the same thing. Both of them mean it takes time.

Paper does not hold time. That is the use of paper and the limit of paper.

◆ Thirty–Seven Years Later, Two Numbers

In 1977 that country's Supreme Court took a case. In one state, becoming a prison guard required meeting a height and a weight standard. Five feet two inches, and a hundred and twenty pounds. A twenty–two–year–old woman wanted to apply; she met the height and weighed a hundred and ten. She was ten pounds short.

Of women, thirty–three percent were excluded by the height rule and twenty–two percent by the weight rule before they could even apply, and the Court asked whether those two numbers were necessary to do the job, found that they were not, and struck the standard down. A person had been folded into two numbers, and the two numbers had nothing to do with the work. While the standard stood, though, they worked as if they did.

◆ Fold It and Something Goes Inward

Between 1940 and 1977 is thirty–seven years. What changed in between was not people. It was the paper. Folding has one property: fold something and an inside is created. What goes inside does not disappear. It is still there and it cannot be seen. In chapter thirteen the same thing gets said about a review form, and the review form is a descendant of this sheet.

Which is why folding cannot be blamed. To hand along a person without folding them you would have to show the whole person, and for that the receiving side would have to live with them. You cannot do that five million times. **Without folding, nobody gets transmitted at all.**

Where folding goes wrong is somewhere else. It goes wrong when the person holding the folded sheet takes the sheet for the person. The moment what is not written on the paper becomes **what is not there.**

◆ Is There a Way to Hand Someone Along Unfolded

This is where I did not reach the end.

I thought about ways to transmit a person without folding. More boxes? More boxes means more places that fold. Let people write freely? Then people who write well do better, and that is a ruler too. Meet and talk? That works up to a certain number of people.

More plausible than getting rid of the paper is the person receiving the paper remembering that there is an inside — but that cannot be called a method. It is a posture. I held onto this for a long time wanting to write down one method, and I do not think I will have an answer here even by the end of this book.

◆ In Short

	The 1940 form	The 1977 standard
What was written	Eleven boxes, nearly all unchosen	Height and weight, two numbers
What was not	What they did, knew, chose	Whether they could do the job
The thirty-seven years between	What changed was the paper	

◆ Today

Open your resume and write down **three things that are not on it**. By hand, in the blank space on the back, is fine, and one rule for choosing: leave out anything that has a box and you simply did not fill in. That is just something unwritten. You are looking for **things with no box to write them in**. Once all three are down, you can see how much that sheet is saying about you.

◆ Where This Chapter Comes From

The 1940 form is the United States Alien Registration Form (AR-2), and the 1977 case is *Dothard v. Rawlinson* in the U.S. Supreme Court. The list of fields, the two standards, and the thirty-three and twenty-two percent were confirmed at the level of public sources cross-read against one another.

I could open neither the original form nor the opinion; the site hosting the opinion was blocked from where I was working. The numbers are the spine of this chapter and should be read in the opinion itself before publication.

Three things were cut. The story that 1950s resumes carried age, weight, parents' origins and a photograph appears in many pieces of writing, but those pieces may be copying one another, so it is out. When the resume became standard is sourced only to company blog posts, so that is out too. And the frequent claim that a letter of self-recommendation

written by one man in 1482 was the world's first resume is not used, because that letter is a different kind of paper from the one this chapter is looking at.

Two more were noted and not used: a company's employee records from 1875 to 1946 with race written on them and photographs attached to some, and a newspaper's 1973 help-wanted section split into three columns. Using all four would turn this chapter into a history of discrimination, and this book cannot be that book.

Part One ends here. We looked at when we began counting people, at why we count the easy thing, and at what goes inward once the count is written down.

There is one way to see what went inward. Take away what is written on the outside. Part Two is that, and there is not one piece of outside material in it.

Part Two • Take It Away and Look

Part One was about measuring. Part Two goes to the places where there is nothing to measure.

Four people appear. Someone who cannot do anything yet. Someone stopped for a while. Someone handing back, one at a time, what they used to be able to do. Someone skilled with nowhere left to use it. All four are at or near zero.

There is not one piece of outside material in this part.
No papers, no statistics, no history. Only what I saw.

That was done on purpose. Bring material into these four places and the person standing there becomes a case, and once they are a case, what this book is trying to do stops right there. Part One was about the

devices that turn people into cases. Doing the same thing in Part Two would be the book breaking its own word.

So this part runs without numbers. What you should be left with after four chapters is one thing. **What people do in those four places resembles itself.** Part Three starts from the resemblance.

4 · Someone Who Cannot Do Anything Yet

◆ That Room

The day the child was born I was at the hospital and the family had come. Nobody in that room asked the child anything. There was nothing to ask. The child had done nothing that day and would not do anything for some time. And people had gathered.

What they did, having gathered, was look. That was all of it.

◆ Make a List of What They Can Do

Write down what a newborn cannot do and the list is long. Cannot walk, cannot speak, cannot even eat without help. Holding the head up takes months, and

the day they roll over the household makes a noise about it, and the reason for the noise is exactly that: it means there is that little they can do. Make a list of what they can do and the list is nearly empty, and beside that empty list the people in the room put that person at the center.

In that room the order is inverted. The one who can do least is furthest in.

◆ Nobody Finds That Strange

It is not like that elsewhere. In an office the ones who can do things are at the center, and in a classroom too. The person who talks most in a meeting is usually the person who can do most, and when someone who can do nothing comes in, the room gets tighter. I am not saying that is bad. In a place where work is done, turning that way is natural, and if it did not turn that way the work would not get done.

But in that room it turns the other way. And they are the same people. Someone who spent the afternoon going over a subordinate's numbers walks into that room in the evening and gives up the center to the one who can do nothing. Nobody ordered it and nobody taught it; it switches by itself at the threshold.

So this can be said. **We know how to do both.** We know how to count people by usefulness and we know how to not count them, and it is not that we do not know how to stop. We do it in some places and not in others.

◆ One Answer to Clear Out of the Way First

There is an explanation that usually comes up here. We are investing, holding something back because it will be useful later. In that case the baby is an investment.

But nobody in that room behaves that way. Nobody holds a child while calculating what the child will do for them later. If someone did, we would spot it at once. When a person starts talking that way the room goes quiet. And when it is certain that the child will never be useful later, that room stays the same. You can see it beside a child born ill — the arithmetic has hit the floor and the seat at the center has not moved.

So the explanation is wrong. Investment does not explain that room.

◆ A Baby Does Not Apologize

Line the four people of Part Two up in advance and something catches. **Only the baby does not apologize.**

Someone laid up ill apologizes to the person who came to visit. Someone old who has stopped being able to do things says they are nothing but a burden. Someone whose work has gone explains, without

being asked, what they used to do. In all three the receiving side hands something over.

The baby hands nothing over. It receives and does not apologize, and nobody calls that shameless.

Which raises a question. **When do we learn to apologize for receiving?** Something absent at birth appears at some point; there is a day on which a person learns that receiving carries a price, and I do not know when that day is, but after it the thing runs for life.

The other three chapters of Part Two are the story of paying that price.

◆ Then Why Only There

This is where I cannot answer.

With a baby, stopping the count is easy. Nobody taught us and everybody does it, including with a

stranger's baby. But the same thing does not work with adults. In front of someone long ill, someone out of work, someone old, the stopping does not come by itself; it takes effort, and the fact that it takes effort already means it is different. Both of them can do nothing, and it only works on one side.

I do not know this one. There seems to be something between a person who has not done anything yet and a person who can no longer do it, and I have thought about what that something is for a long time without getting my hand on it. A few explanations come up. There is still time ahead. It is my own blood. It is small. Not one of them stretches as far as a stranger's baby.

So I stop here and go to the next chapter. The other three chapters of Part Two are about the people who can no longer do it.

◆ Today

Take one person you met today and look at them as someone doing nothing. That means erasing, for a moment, what they do. Fold away what they accomplished today, what they earn, what position they hold, and look at them.

It will feel strange. The strangeness is what this book is about. One person is enough, and it does not have to last long.

◆ Where This Chapter Comes From

There are no outside facts in this chapter. No statistics, no studies, no other people's books. That is true of all four chapters in Part Two. What is here is what I saw and what I thought while standing there. There is a reason for that: what this part is trying to do is not to prove something but to make visible something already being done, and material cannot do that.

One thing to note instead. Clearing away the "useful later" explanation uses the case of a child born ill, and that is written as a thing commonly known rather than as a case, and it is not anyone's particular household.

5 • Someone Who Cannot Do Anything for a While

◆ The First Week, and a Month Later

I was badly hurt in an accident once. This is my own story. In the first week friends came. A lot of them came. They came and said good things. It will work out, you will be up soon. And see you later.

A month later only a few were left. Those few came and said the same thing. See you later. The ones who stayed to the end were family. Family did not say much. They did the nursing. They held the place. Over that time my body recovered and I left the hospital.

Writing it down afterward, one thing caught. The people who came in the first week gave words and the people who stayed to the end did work, and both

came out of the same feeling, and one lasts a week and one lasts to the end.

◆ The First Thing to Go

You would think that once you are ill and lying down, being ill is the biggest thing, but watching from beside it, that is not quite so; the body hurts in its own way, and separately from that, something else drains out. Things to do. A reason to get up in the morning, a schedule that puts you somewhere by a certain hour, a place where someone is waiting. All of that is lifted away overnight.

Once it is lifted, something odd happens. The day gets longer, and in that long day who you are goes dim. The body is the same and the name is the same, and only now does it become visible that everything that made that person that person was hanging on the outside.

◆ In the First Week People Come

The first week and a month later are different.

In the first week there is a lot of contact. Startled people ask after you, the close ones visit, and even people who had drifted away get in touch once. In that week the sick person is not alone.

A month later it goes quiet.

Calling this coldness is easy, and wrong in proportion to how easy it is. The people who came did not turn bad. They had a reason to come and the reason ran out. *How did it go?* has nothing left once it is asked. *Do you need anything?* gets embarrassing after a couple of rounds. When the errands run out, people are not sure what to bring next.

And right there the sick person learns something. That nearly all of the talk around them had been about what they did. That the talk stopped when the doing stopped.

◆ The One or Two That Do Not Shrink

Not everything shrinks, though. One or two remain.

Look at the ones who remain and they have one thing in common. They have no errand. They do not ask, they do not offer to do something, they stop by and leave. Some of them sit a long while without saying anything. They did not come on an errand in the first place, so when the errands run out they come anyway.

A relationship with an errand ends when the errand ends. That is not the difference between bad people and good people; it is a difference in what joined you at the start.

This is what a person learns while ill. Which of the things around them was attached to them and which was attached to their work. Ordinarily you cannot tell, because the two arrive together. They only separate when the work stops.

◆ The One Receiving Apologizes

One thing should be written down here. The sick person apologizes.

Go to visit and the one lying down says sorry first. Sorry to make you come when you are busy. Sorry I cannot get up. Sorry the place is a mess. The person whose body hurts apologizes to the person whose body does not.

It is a strange arrangement and nobody finds it strange; if anything, the absence of the apology is what stands out.

Why does it happen? Because the position of only receiving is hard to bear. Something has to be handed over for the books to balance and there is nothing to hand over, so an apology gets handed over instead. An apology is the only thing that can be produced by a body that will not move.

So an ill person is doing two things at once, getting better and being sorry, and the second one costs something too, and what it costs is written down nowhere. The baby in chapter four does not do it.

◆ About the Ones Who Stay

Here is where I have no answer.

I cannot blame the ones who thin out. It is true that after a month there is no reason to come, and manufacturing a reason in order to go is strange in its own way, and the sick person is the first to notice that a visitor who forced themselves to come is sitting less comfortably than the rest.

So the question turns into this. Why do people not know how to go without an errand? Everyone managed it in front of a baby.

The stopping I wrote about in the last chapter does not work well here. I could not find the reason.

People who have gone without an errand say it is not hard, and for people who have not, it is the hardest thing there is, and it looks like something you could learn and it also looks like something learning does not reach.

Chapter six is about the ones who can no longer do it at all, not for a while. There the question gets bigger.

◆ Today

Get in touch with someone who has been ill a long time, **with no errand.**

Do not ask how they are. Do not ask what they need. Above all do not ask whether they are getting better. Say you thought of them and got in touch. That is all of it.

You will feel you cannot do it because you have nothing to say. It is correct that you have nothing to

say. The point where you believe you need something to say in order to make contact is the thing this chapter is pointing at.

◆ Where This Chapter Comes From

There are no outside facts in this chapter either. That is true of all four chapters in Part Two.

One thing should be written down. The sequence — they come in the first week and not a month later — is something many people describe similarly, but I have not measured it. I do not know how common it is or how long it takes. This chapter does not claim that sequence as a general fact. It uses it as one case the author saw.

I am not even sure it is measurable. Within what I searched, I found no study of it.

6 · Someone Who Stops Being Able To

◆ That Day

My grandmother lay in bed for six months. The first thing she stopped being able to do was eat by herself. Lifting a spoon is something a person does for a whole life without once thinking about it. Once that starts to fail, from then on someone has to be beside you.

Over six months my grandmother handed things back one at a time. And at the end she left me one sentence.

Grow up and be a fine person.

Then she died.

I do not remember what I said back. What I remember is only that sentence. The last thing a person who could no longer do anything did was to want something for me.

◆ Handed Back One at a Time

Growing old does not arrive all at once. It arrives one thing at a time.

One year the driving stops, a few years later stairs get avoided, after that the handwriting shakes, and then names come slowly, and putting one thing down can take years or it can finish overnight, and either way what was put down does not come back. It is handing back, one at a time, what you used to be able to do, and the place where something was handed back does not refill.

And every time something is handed back, it gets counted.

◆ While It Is Still Hidden

Handing things back one at a time has a stage before it. The hiding.

At first it is concealed. To avoid being caught out of breath on the stairs they rest a step and then go on, and when a name will not come they steer the conversation somewhere that name is not needed, and once the handwriting starts to shake they reduce the occasions for writing. What is *cannot* gets made to look like *does not*.

That stage runs quite long, and it is the loneliest part. The surroundings do not know, so nobody helps, and the person spends the whole day braced against being found out. Neither having handed it back nor still holding it, they carry it alone.

Then comes the day of being found out. **For them that is the second loss.** One loss was the day they stopped being able to and another is the day it was seen, and the surroundings count the day it was seen

as the first one. The long stretch before it is counted by nobody.

◆ This Time the Person Counts Themselves

That is what is different here from the two chapters before. The person doing the counting changes.

A baby does not count itself. It does not know it can do nothing. With someone laid up ill, mostly the surroundings do the counting; the person is tied up in getting better and the counting happens outside them.

Growing old is not like that. The person counts. On the day the car keys are handed over, the one who knows most exactly what has been subtracted is the person handing them over, and they redo that arithmetic every day. They do it without anyone counting for them.

Which is why this gets said.

I am no use now.

I am just a burden.

◆ The Comfort Uses the Same Ruler

Once that is said, what the person beside them says back is almost fixed.

Don't talk like that. You're still sharp. You're better than I am. This house runs because of you.

They are good words, and nearly the only words available in that moment. But take them apart and they are all doing one thing. **They are insisting that some usefulness is still left.**

Which leaves the ruler in place. The ruler that says there is worth where there is something you can do and none where there is not, now being held by the comforting side as well. The person comforted is lighter for a moment, puts one more thing down next

month, and comes back to the same place, and this time there is one less thing to insist on.

Ten times out of ten it is a losing fight. Their side shrinks every year and this side loses one argument every year.

◆ So What Do You Say

This is the wall in this chapter.

I understand that you must not answer usefulness with usefulness, and I have not yet built what to say instead. *It's all right not to be useful* does not work. Anyone who has said it out loud knows. It does not land as comfort. It lands as a verdict.

Saying nothing does not seem to be the answer either. No reply to that sentence sounds like agreement.

What worked least badly, over several tries, was not answering and moving sideways. Not arguing with

the sentence and not letting it slide past either — just going toward what happened today. That is not because it is the answer. It is what I do for lack of anything better.

◆ "What Did You Used to Do?"

This is the question people reach for most often in front of an old person.

There is nothing bad in it. It is on the courteous side. It is offered in order to stand the person up, and in fact an old person's face does brighten when the question comes.

But this question uses the same ruler. Because no usefulness is visible in the person now, it **borrow**s **some from the past**. They used to run something big, and borrowed things have to go back, and when the conversation ends you return to the present.

And the people who get asked this often know that.
They know which time this is.

◆ Today

Ask one old person something other than what they
used to do.

Which means asking about now. What they enjoy
most these days. What they ate today. What annoys
them most. What strikes them as strangest about
people now.

The last one is good. It is a question they have to
answer, there is nothing to borrow from the past,
and the answer that comes could only come from
them.

Then listen. That is all of it.

◆ Where This Chapter Comes From

There are no outside facts in this chapter either. That is true of all four chapters in Part Two.

One note. *I am no use now* and *Don't talk like that* are written as things commonly said, not as anyone's particular words. They are not quotations.

And the passage saying that not answering and moving sideways worked least badly is within what the author has tried; it is not a recommended method, and there is probably something better, and this book did not find it.

7 • Someone Skilled With Nowhere to Use It

◆ Nothing Was Handed Back

The last chapter was about handing things back one at a time. Driving handed back, stairs handed back, names handed back. The more that is handed back the less there is you can do, and the less there is, the more it gets counted. At least that has a certain internal consistency.

This chapter is the case where nothing was handed back.

I have stood in that place. What I am best at is saying what I honestly mean, plainly. I could do it then and I can do it now. It never shrank and it never rusted. There was simply nowhere to use it.

What changed was the surroundings. Nobody told me I could no longer do anything. The way people spoke was the same and what they called me was the same. The atmosphere changed.

Atmosphere is the only word I can find. I cannot put my finger on what changed and write it down, and not being able to point at it, I cannot dispute it, and not being able to dispute it, I just sit in it. That is the hardest part of this place.

◆ Unchanged and It Still Falls

There is one way this person differs from the three before.

The baby cannot do it yet. The sick person stopped for a while. The old person shrinks one thing at a time. In all three, what they could do really was absent or reduced, and so if worth went down alongside it there was at least a reason to shrug at.

Even if we want to believe that people do not count, the counting was not flatly wrong.

This person is different. What they could do yesterday they can do today. The hands and the head are the same, and the twenty years stacked up are still there. The only thing that changed is where it could be used.

And the worth falls.

So that worth was not hanging on ability.

In the previous three chapters I could not say this. Ability really had decreased, so the drop in worth could be charged to ability. In this chapter that excuse is gone. One side was held fixed and only the other moved, and it moved, so the fact that the two were not tied together simply shows.

That is why Part Two ends here.

◆ How Long the Word "Unchanged" Stays True

This chapter stands on the word *unchanged*. Then it is only fair to write down how long that word stays true.

Unused, it rusts. Hands do and speech does. With no place to use it for several years a person really does get duller, and once they are duller it becomes impossible to sort out whether the original drop in worth was about ability or not, because by then the two are mixed together.

The person starts to doubt it too. Nobody is using me, so have I actually lost it — and once that doubt arrives, trying becomes frightening. Not trying means no confirmation, and with no confirmation the doubt is the only thing that grows.

So the *unchanged* in this chapter is true only for a while at the start. **The worth falls first, inside that while.** Later the ability comes down after it until the

gap is no longer visible, and from that point the fall in worth can be charged to ability.

To see it you have to look early.

◆ They Start Explaining Without Being Asked

A habit develops in a person standing there.

They start explaining. Without being asked, they say what they used to do. Where they worked and for how many years and what they were responsible for, and they do it with people they have just met and they do it again with people who already know. The sheet of paper listing their history gets longer every year.

In chapter six I wrote about asking an old person what they used to do, and called it a question that borrows usefulness from the past.

Here the person does it to themselves. Nobody borrows it for them, so they borrow it alone.

It looks pitiable, and that feeling of pity is exactly the place this chapter is pointing at. Why pitiable?

Because they look like someone who has to borrow in order to stand.

◆ "Even So"

There is a thing people say to someone in this position.

You are a person of worth even so.

It is said with good intent, and it overlaps with what this book has been trying to say throughout, but there is one place where it catches for the person receiving it.

It is the "even so."

Even so means something in front of it has fallen away. It is continuing a sentence with both parties knowing what fell. So that one phrase carries comfort and verdict together. The listener hears both.

Should it then not be said? That does not seem right either. Anyone who has tried knows that saying nothing is worse.

This chapter stops here too. Whether that sentence is comfort or insult, I cannot yet sort out. The same words hold a person up on one day and push them away on another. I have looked several times at what separates the two, at what is different in the person saying it, and it has not come into my hands.

◆ In Short

The four places Part Two looked at.

Who	What they can do	Who counts	What shows there
Cannot do anything yet	Nothing	Nobody counts	We know how to not count
Cannot for a while	Stopped	The surroundings count	What was attached to me
Stops being able to	Shrinking	They count themselves	Comfort uses the same ruler
Skilled, nowhere to use it	Unchanged	Everyone counts	Worth was not hanging on ability

The bottom row holds up the three above it from behind.

Read the four rows downward and one more thing shows. **The receiving side hands something over.** The ill person hands over an apology, the old person hands over concealment, the person out of work

hands over an explanation, and all three are things a body that will not move can still produce. The only one of the four who hands nothing over is the baby, and the baby is the only one nobody asks it of.

◆ Today

Ask someone who has lost their work about something other than work.

Do not ask what they are up to these days either. That is work talk too. Any question about what they are accomplishing right now is the same ruler.

Weather is fine. Food is fine. Something you saw yesterday is better. Making a ten-minute space **where that person has to explain nothing** is close to everything this chapter can offer.

◆ Where This Chapter Comes From

There are no outside facts in this chapter either. That is true of all four chapters in Part Two.

What actually happens in a place where work disappears has been studied with numbers, and that is used in chapter sixteen, and it is not used here because Part Two is the place for looking at one person at a time. Also it would mean telling the same story twice.

And the passage about *even so* is one phrase taken apart, not research. I could not find material asking people who received that sentence how it actually felt.

Part Three • So How Do You Look

Up to here it was looking. From Part Three it is doing.

Four chapters and four things. Saying a person's name. Listening to the end. Not asking first what someone does for a living. Not trying to fix it. All four are small. Not one takes more than a day.

Before starting, something has to be said. A **book of things to do already exists**. It came out in 1936 and it still sells, and it lays out how to deal with people point by point and the points are mostly right.

So the first chapter of this part starts from that book. Not to refute it. To see whether the same actions can be recommended **with a different reason underneath**.

Whether same action plus different reason makes a different book is a question I ended up asking myself, and it is in chapter eight exactly as I asked it.

Said in advance: not one of these four chapters closes cleanly. All four are things worth doing, and all four hit a wall at the end on the question of how far. The wall is left standing where it is.

8 • Carnegie Was Right, and His Reason Was Wrong

◆ A Book of Things to Do Already Exists

Up to here it was looking. From Part Three it is doing. And a book of things to do already exists. It came out in 1936 and it still sells. It sets out how to deal with people point by point and the points are mostly right. I am not writing this chapter to refute it.

The third principle of its second part is this.

A person's name is to that person the sweetest and most important sound in any language.

Remember names, use them, do not get them wrong. This book recommends the same thing. That is what

this chapter asks you to do as well.

◆ The Example He Attached to It

What changes the story is the example attached to the principle. The person the book names ran a political campaign, claimed he could remember fifty thousand names, and the book records that this ability put a president in office. That is the evidence for the principle. Remember names and this becomes possible.

The purpose of remembering was votes. The book says so itself.

So there is no need to import anyone else's criticism. The book wrote it down, and writing it down is the honest thing to have done. It says in its own title that it will teach you to move people. It never hid anything.

Which leaves this. The action is the same and the work it does is different.

◆ Why a Name, of All Things

Put a different reason under the same action. Why should you say a person's name? Not because they like it. They do like it, but that is a result, not a reason.

A name is the only form of address with no connection to what a person does. Every other form hangs on something: a title stops working when the post is gone; a professional form of address gets awkward once the person leaves. Every honorific attaches to a role or a relation, so when that shifts, the word shakes with it.

It becomes clear if you recall the four people in Part Two. Someone who cannot do anything yet, someone stopped for a while, someone handing things back one at a time, someone skilled with nowhere to use

it. For all four, a form of address came off. The name stayed. It is the one thing that did not shrink. That is why you say it.

◆ Where the Name Cannot Be Said

Something catches here immediately. In the language I write in, there are a great many relationships in which a name cannot be said.

You do not say the name of someone older. No child says a parent's name and no student says a teacher's. At work, people above you are addressed by title. Saying the name is the moment it becomes rude, and the territory where that is true is far wider than in English.

So transplanting this chapter looks useless. Some of its use really does shrink. But what shrinks is replaced by something else becoming visible.

The less a name can be said, the more is hanging on the form of address. Manager, teacher, ma'am, sir. all of these bind a person to what they are right now, so when that changes there is nothing left to call them. Plenty of people have stood there hesitating over what to call someone who retired. That hesitation is what this chapter points at.

There are one or two usable forms. There is a polite particle that attaches to a given name rather than a role. It is not complete; it is still awkward upward, and awkwardness means that place is still empty.

So practising this chapter in my language is slightly different. Where a name can be said, say it. Where it cannot, look once at what the person's form of address is hanging on. Even that shows you something.

Here is my own case. The only people who call me by my name are family. Outside, I am *teacher*;

almost everyone uses that. It is not a rude form of address. It is honorific, and I do not mind it.

What is hanging on it, though, becomes visible in the people who have left that post. A person who was *teacher* becomes *boss* afterward — the word applied to any adult male whose place you cannot locate. Being applicable to anyone means it points at no one.

◆ He Changed His Own Name

There is something to add. The man who wrote that book was born with a different spelling. He later altered one letter to match the spelling of a famous industrialist of the day, to whom he was neither related nor connected in any way. It was simply a name people knew.

I have no interest in using this to diminish him. Diminishing is easy, and in proportion to how easy it is, it leaves nothing. What the fact does tell us is one thing. He understood better than anyone that a name

is a useful object. He understood it well enough to change his. In that world a name is capital too, and if it is capital you trade up.

That world is what this book is trying to leave.

◆ Isn't It the Same on the Receiving End

Here is where I cannot tie the knot. Even if the reason differs, doesn't the receiving side feel the same thing? A person whose name is said does not know what the sayer was thinking. A name memorized for votes and a name memorized because it is that person are both pleasant in the moment of being said. Then who is the sorting of reasons for?

An answer presents itself: it is for the one saying it, because a different reason makes the next action different: a name memorized for an election is of no use after the election; a name memorized because of the person keeps getting used. Plausible, and not entirely convincing. If the receiving side never finds

out, where does the difference live? I stood with that question a long time, and that is as far as I got.

◆ Today

Say someone's name once more today. Not just before asking for something — when there is nothing to ask at all. A name said because there is business is part of the business; only a name said with no business arrives as a name. Once in passing, once while greeting, and that is enough.

And try it with someone you only ever address by title. That is much harder, and what this chapter is trying to say shows most clearly in the difficulty.

◆ Where This Chapter Comes From

Every fact in this chapter is inside that book. The year 1936, the third principle of the second part, and the example attached to it. Open the book to the

page and it is confirmed. Only one line is quoted, because pulling in more would make this a summary of someone else's book, and this chapter is not here to summarize it.

One thing could not be written. It is recorded in several places that a novelist of the day left a fairly sharp remark about this book, and I could never find where that remark was published. The words float around identically in many places, and things that float around identically are not a source. So it is not used at all. And the year he changed the spelling of his name differs between sources, so no year is given.

9 • What It Costs to Listen to the End

◆ The Hard Part Is Not Holding Back

People say the hard part of listening is holding back the urge to cut in. Half right. Look at the numbers and there is something that catches earlier. **Asking comes first.** And more gets caught in the asking.

◆ Eighteen Seconds of What

There is a study from 1984. Seventy-four office visits were recorded and gone through. Patients completed their opening statement in seventeen of them, which is twenty-three percent. In fifty-one, sixty-nine percent, the doctor cut in and turned the questioning toward a specific symptom, and the average time to that point was eighteen seconds.

The eighteen seconds travelled widely. Something fell off along the way: what that study counted as an interruption. It counted four things, and the first of them is a closed-ended question.

When did that pain start?

That is not a rude thing to say. If anything it is the sound of someone doing their job well, and it stands the patient's story aside and begins asking what the diagnosis needs, and from there the questions come in a row. So what the study measured was not rudeness. **It was the point where listening turns into processing.** Eighteen seconds is not how long until someone was cut off; it is how long until the person in front of them became a case.

◆ Thirty-Five Years Later

In 2019 another study looked at the same room, and its number is harder. In thirty-six percent of visits

the doctor asked at all what the patient had come for, and where they did ask, the median time to interruption was eleven seconds, and where they did not interrupt, patients finished in six seconds.

Not asking at all is the bigger number, not interrupting. Two out of three were not cut off; they never started. And look at the last figure. Left alone, it is six seconds. Six seconds is the amount of patience required.

I am not going to put the two studies side by side and say things got better or worse. They counted different things. The 1984 study counted time to interruption; the 2019 study counted whether anyone asked. Line up two measurements taken with different rulers and from that point the mismeasuring is ours.

◆ We Assume People Will Talk a Long Time

Look again at the six seconds. Left alone, people finish what they have to say in six seconds.

But what is in our heads at the moment we cut in is not those six seconds. It is an assumption that if this person gets going it will run on. Because of that assumption we move early. We throw in a question to give the thing direction, thinking that is better for both of us.

The assumption is wrong, and that is what the number says. Mostly it is six seconds.

There is a reason we feel it will be long. What we remember are the people who talked a long time. The one who finished in six seconds does not stay in memory; the one who went ten minutes stays sharply, and so the average in our heads is longer than the real one. We meet the next person with that average.

This may be the most useful passage in the chapter. **Knowing the estimate is wrong** is easier than learning to hold back. Holding back takes will. Knowing does not.

◆ The Number Survives and What It Counted Falls Off

By the time eighteen seconds reached the newspapers it had become *doctors do not listen to patients*. The number was not wrong. What fell off was what the number had counted. Once that is gone, what is left is one sentence blaming people.

Read as a chapter about doctors, this one is useless. Doctors are not the only ones who make that turn. The person answering the phone, the counselor, the clerk handling a complaint, the parent listening to a child — all of them make the turn at some point. They have to. Without it the work does not get done. What this chapter wants to look at is not abolishing the turn but the fact that it comes earlier than we think.

Someone was telling me about the abundance of this world. I asked, in the middle, what the ultimate purpose of a life is.

That is not a rude thing to say. The opposite. It is a bigger and deeper question than the story he was telling, and I asked it because I thought it mattered more, and I still think so.

The story ended there. What he had been about to say about abundance I never heard to the end. Good questions cut better.

◆ The Work Still Has to Get Done

Here is where I cannot cleanly divide. Listening to the end is not always right. A doctor has to work after the eighteen seconds. Let every patient say everything they want to say and the number of people seen in a day falls, and by that much someone else does not get seen. So that turn is also for someone's sake.

The six seconds narrows the gap a little. Six seconds to listen to the end is not time nobody can spare. But not every setting finishes in six seconds. Where

listening ends and work begins — I did not draw that line, and I have never seen it drawn.

◆ In Short

Commonly known	What was actually measured
Doctors cut patients off in 18 seconds	Closed questions begin at 18 seconds
Interrupting is the problem	Not asking at all is the bigger number (36%)
Listening to the end takes a long time	Uninterrupted, it ends in 6 seconds

◆ Today

In one conversation today, count the places where you wanted to cut in. Not don't cut in — just count. On your fingers, or afterward from memory.

Counting shows two things. There are more than you thought, and most of them were not rude remarks

but good questions.

If you have room, one more. Once, at a place where you want to cut in, **count to six in your head**. If the person finishes while you are counting, they were a six-second case; if not, ask then. All you lose is six seconds.

◆ Where This Chapter Comes From

The 1984 study is Beckman and Frankel in *Annals of Internal Medicine*, volume 101, number 5, pages 692–696, and the 2019 study is Singh Ospina and others in the *Journal of General Internal Medicine*, volume 34.

I could open neither original. This is public sources cross-read against one another, and the figures and citations are confirmed at that level. Someone should read the originals in a library before publication. This chapter is especially dependent on its numbers.

One thing is not used. Between the two there is a 1999 study on the same subject; I found the citation but could not support its figures, so it is out. And lining all three up turns it into a story about change over time, which, as written above, is not what this material can carry.

10 · Anything but "What Do You Do"

◆ What Do You Ask a Stranger First

Picture it. You have ended up seated next to someone you do not know, you have said hello, and now something has to be said. What do you ask first?

Almost everyone asks the same thing.

| So what do you do?

The question dissolves the awkwardness. That is why everyone uses it. I use it too.

◆ Once They Are in a Box, the Rest Is Set

The moment the answer comes, the person goes into a box, and once the box is set the rest of the conversation flows out of it. Teacher, and you get talk about kids today. Running a shop, and you get talk about the economy. Taking a break right now, and the conversation skips a beat. Plenty of people have felt that skip. Both sides feel it.

The first question you ask decides the next thirty minutes. For thirty minutes we talk about that box. Not about the person.

◆ The Problem Is That There Is No Bad Intent

There is no bad intent in the question. If anything it is interest. It is trying to hand the other person a foothold, trying to make something to talk about. And that interest asks about use first.

In chapter six there was the question of asking an old person what they used to do. Because no usefulness is visible in them now, I wrote, we borrow some from

the past. *What do you do* is the same question in the present tense. It checks first what you are currently useful as.

A kind question using the same ruler. That is the third time this shape appears in Part Three. Remember names, listen to the end, ask what someone does — all of them come from a good place and the measuring instrument is unchanged.

◆ What the Question Gives the Asker

Why is this question so comfortable? Because the asker gets something.

Knowing the other person's box settles how I am supposed to talk. How formal to be, what subjects are allowed, how far a joke can go. Without that information I cannot choose my next sentence. So I ask first.

Which makes this, before it is a question about them, a **question for my own comfort**. It is used to switch off the discomfort that arises in front of a stranger. Once it is off, conversation gets easy.

In my language there is one more thing in front of it. Age.

Not knowing someone's age, I cannot choose my words, because how far to raise the level of politeness is not yet settled, and so in a first meeting people work to find out the age somehow. What year were you born, what was your entering class, what animal year are you. Indirect routes to it are quite well developed.

Age and occupation. Both are used to stand a person up vertically. And both have to be known before speech can come out. To talk with a stranger in my language you have to decide first where to place them. The language itself is built that way.

This is not something that can be fixed. The language is what it is. But using it knowingly and using it unknowingly are different.

I have seen someone's face change when I said what I do. It did not change for the worse. It changed for the better — and whether for better or worse, the fact that it visibly changes is what this chapter is looking at.

There is the other side too, when I was the one asking. I asked a stranger what they did. They said they were out of work at the moment.

The one who stopped at that moment was not them. It was me. I could not find the next sentence. It felt like anything would do and nothing came. The question I threw got stuck on my own side.

That person was probably used to that spot. They will have given that answer and watched the other person stall many times, and the one stalling stalls

freshly every time; the one answering sees the same thing every time.

◆ Make a List and It Becomes a Technique

So what do you ask? This is the wall in this chapter. I tried to make a list of replacement questions and stopped, because once it was made it was a technique. It had turned into an object that reads as *ask these five things and people open up*, and that returns to the book we parted from in chapter eight. Change the action, leave the reason as it was.

So no list. Only this, written down.

Stop once before you ask. Is what I am curious about this person, or this person's use?

I am not satisfied with that either. *Stop and look* is good for not being a technique and, for the same

reason, gives the hand nothing to hold. If I find something better I will change it.

◆ In Short

Question	What it does
"What did you used to do?" (ch. 6)	Borrows usefulness from the past
"What do you do?"	Checks present usefulness first
What they share	Asks the box before the person

◆ Today

With the first person you meet today, **ask something other than their work first**. Not the weather, not the traffic — something about them: how they came to be here, what they were doing before this, what they are enjoying most lately.

And you do not have to ask about work at all. See whether the conversation holds without it. Mostly it does. That is what you are checking today.

◆ Where This Chapter Comes From

There are no outside facts in this chapter.

It is often said that what people ask a stranger first differs from country to country, so I went looking for material. I could not find anything that actually surveyed it. It is plausible and unsupported, and unsupported writing gets read as fact. So it was cut whole.

That space is filled with two scenes the author lived. This is a chapter with no case material, so if those two were empty the chapter would be generalities.

11 · Not Trying to Fix It

◆ That Time

Someone brought up something hard. What they said was three short things.

It hurts. It is hard. I do not know what to do.

I said this.

This time will pass too. A day will come, far off, when you can tell this story and smile.

It is true. I believe it. I still believe it. It is true that it passes and true that the day comes when you can tell it smiling.

But there is no chance that what that person had to say ended at those three things. They got three in and then listened to me.

◆ The Eye Inside the Wish to Fix

The wish to fix is a good impulse. It means spending attention on someone else's trouble, and spending it costs something. People do not do it for just anyone. But there is an eye inside that impulse. **An eye that sees a thing as broken.**

A broken thing can be fixed. From the fixing side it becomes a task, and once it is a task, the person becomes a task. A task that costs effort and attention, but a task. Which produces something strange: while you are working hard at fixing, the person in front of you gradually stops being visible, and what is visible is a problem to be solved.

◆ The Speed at Which a Solution Arrives

The last chapter had the eighteen seconds — the place where listening turns into processing arrives earlier than you think. The same thing happens here, and here it is faster.

When someone opens a hard story, a solution arrives almost immediately. By their third sentence one is already up. From then on the remaining job is waiting for them to finish, and while waiting you listen less, because you are polishing what you will say.

So the moment a solution arrives is the moment listening ends. The words keep coming in and the listening has stopped. And in most cases the solution is not even wrong. It would be easier if it were wrong. Because it is right you say it, because it is right they cannot argue, and because they cannot argue the conversation is over.

◆ Why They Are Not Grateful

It is common to feel let down after fixing something. You said a good thing out of good feeling and their face does not open. It is because what they were looking for was not an answer.

A person looking for an answer asks for one. They say *what should I do*. If that did not come, they were not after an answer, and what they were after instead is often not known to them either — but one thing is clear. **They wanted to finish telling it.** A story told to the end and a story handed an answer midway become different stories, and what is left when they remember it later is different.

◆ Whose Discomfort Gets Switched Off

Here is where this overlaps with the chapter before.

What do you do was written as a question that switches off the asker's discomfort. The solution is the same.

Listening to someone's hard story makes the listener uncomfortable. It feels like sitting there doing nothing, and it is hard to bear that they are suffering and I am still, and the fastest way to switch off that discomfort is to do something, and the thing available in that moment is a solution.

So here is what happens the instant a solution comes out. Before their problem is solved, **my discomfort goes off first**. And once it is off, I am a person who did something.

That is the third time this shape appears in Part Three. Remembering a name, asking what someone does, fixing — all of them came from a good place and all of them return something to the giver, and there is nothing wrong with good acts returning something. But looking at **whose discomfort** that return switches off shows you who the act was aimed at.

That is also why listening alone is hard. Your own discomfort has to stay on.

◆ So Do You Just Sit There

This is the line I could not draw in this chapter.

Where not fixing separates from leaving someone to it, I do not know.

There really are people who need help. Only listening and doing nothing is choosing the easy side. Listening is sometimes easier, and you can pick the easy thing and call it respect. Conversely, not putting out a hand where a hand is needed is neglect. The line is somewhere between, and it moves from person to person and day to day. I have one guess: not doing it until asked is wrong less often. It is a guess, so I will not write it down as a rule.

◆ Today

If someone tells you something hard today, **go to the end without saying the solution.** You cannot stop one from arriving, so let it arrive and just keep it behind your teeth. Only until they have finished.

You do not have to produce it afterward either. If *what should I do* comes, say it then; if it does not, do not. Try it and your hands will itch, and the itch is what this chapter is pointing at.

◆ Where This Chapter Comes From

There are no outside facts in this chapter. Only what the author saw and thought while standing there.

One thing to note. *The moment a solution arrives, listening ends* has the same shape as what the study in chapter nine showed, but that study does not support this chapter, because it was measured in an examining room and this is ordinary talk between people. Same shape is not the same thing.

Part Three ends here. Having read four chapters, one thing will catch. Everything written here is done toward other people, and the place it fails hardest is in front of the person closest to you. Part Four is about that.

Part Four • Between Two People

The four things in Part Three mostly work in front of a stranger. Part Four is the places where they do not.

Three chapters. Home, work, the street. In order of closeness.

The first is the closest place and the place where it fails hardest. That is backwards, and there is a reason it is backwards. Care produces expectation, and expectation brings a ruler with it. So the person we love most is the person we measure first.

The second chapter is outside the house. There the same thing has been built into a procedure, and the person doing the measuring does not feel bad about it. It is their job.

The third is strangers. The people we pass in a day we know only as roles, and this part ends on the finding that they are not nothing to us, and Part Five opens from there.

12 · The Closer They Are, the Sooner We Count

◆ Where It Fails Hardest

The four things in Part Three were all doable. Say a name, listen to the end, do not ask about work first, swallow the solution. They work in front of a stranger and they work well enough with people you have known a long time.

There is one place where they fail hardest. In front of the person you live with.

That is backwards. It is the person you have known longest, know most about, care most for, and that is where it collapses first. It collapses harder in proportion to the caring.

◆ Saying the Word Here

There is a word this book has been holding back. Dignity. In eleven chapters it has not been used once, because using it empties the room of anything further to say. There is no sentence that follows *a person has dignity*, and in front of a sentence that cannot be argued with the reader stops thinking.

In this chapter it gets used. Because this is the place where it is shaved down first.

Outside, the word has force. It is written into law and into regulations, and when a place stops treating people as people there is somewhere to take it. The review form in chapter thirteen was eventually changed. That is how the outside runs — slowly, late, and running.

At home there is none of that. No written rules, nowhere to take it, and above all **the one shaving it down is the person who cares most**. What someone who cares does is not called shaving by anybody. So

at home the thing goes on for decades with no name on it.

Dignity is not shaved down far away. It is shaved down first at the closest range.

That is this chapter. So what follows is not a set of small domestic habits. It is looking at where the word actually gives way.

◆ The Questions Are Always the Same

Think about what gets asked of a child at home. What did you get today. When is the exam. Are you done. What gets asked of a husband or wife has something of the same. How did that thing go. Did you get it this time. What gets asked of a parent is a little different and still a measuring question. Did you take your medicine. Did you get to the hospital.

Not one of them is wrong. All of them come out of worry, and without worry nobody asks. But worry always worries about one box. The score box, the results box, the body box. So while worrying you keep asking about that box, and after some years the questions asked about that person have narrowed to the one.

◆ That Sentence Is a Way of Saying I Love You

I had that written down and then sat still a long time. Something in it is wrong.

Mother, have you eaten? is not a measuring question. It is a way of saying I love you. In households using my language it is rare for anyone to tell their mother they love her, and that sentence is what goes in the place where it would go. Did you take your medicine. Have you eaten. Aren't you cold. The one saying it knows and the one hearing it knows.

So was the section before it wrong? Half wrong.

Corrected, it reads like this.

It is also true that the sentence means I love you.

Only, there is one translation.

When there is one thing to say and only one vessel to carry it, the speaker does not notice they are short and the receiver has to take everything through that one. And then on a day when the body is fine there is nothing to say. Having nothing to say, you do not call.

This is nobody's fault. The language is shaped that way. But a person who knows there is only the one is different from a person who does not. The one who knows goes looking for a second sentence.

◆ Expectation Brings a Ruler

Why do we measure harder the closer we are?

Expectation.

There is no expectation toward a stranger. Whatever the person in the next seat does for a living, my day does not change. So I do not measure them; I simply see them. With someone close, my day changes according to them, and if it changes I stand to lose or gain, and where loss and gain are involved, measuring becomes natural. Expectation is evidence of love and it arrives carrying a ruler.

So the difficulty of this chapter does not come from a shortage of feeling. It comes from having the feeling. The four people in Part Two are the same. The place where someone who cannot do anything yet, or who is stopped for a while, gets measured most in the world is probably inside the house. The world passes by not knowing. The house knows. The side that knows is the side that counts.

Our youngest is three. The oldest is seventeen and the second is fifteen. The space between is empty. We lost the third and the fourth. My wife was hurt far worse than I was. The child who came fifth is the youngest. In our house that child is recovery, and a blessing.

On the child's birthday I said it. My beloved youngest. I did not hesitate. There was not one reason to hesitate.

And something should be written down. I do not ask my children about scores. I think process matters more than result, that you do what is in front of you with everything you have and take what comes out of it.

But writing this chapter something caught. Process is a ruler too. *Did you try hard* is gentler than asking for a score, and gentle in proportion to how little room it leaves: you can say the score was bad and be done; the sentence *you did not try* attaches to the

whole person. It may be that instead of a score I was holding a different ruler.

To a three-year-old that ruler does not get applied. There is nothing to apply it to. It is the same room as chapter four. What happens to that room as the child grows? That is what this chapter is asking me.

◆ Only the Part You Can Repeat

One more thing. Among the things a close person does, we ask first about **what can be carried to other people.**

If a child wins something, that story can be used at the next gathering. The story that the child drew alone for a long time has nowhere to be used. So the prize gets asked about and the drawing does not. Nobody decided not to ask. The usable side simply comes out of the mouth first.

This is the quietest thing that happens inside a house. Nobody intended anything bad, and one person's day is divided into pieces that can be carried elsewhere and pieces that cannot, and the pieces that cannot are asked about by nobody until they never happened.

◆ At Home the Name Is Least Said

In chapter eight I wrote that a name is the only form of address unconnected to usefulness. Carry that sentence home and something strange appears.

At home names are barely used. Mom, dad, dear, older brother, older sister. All of them are position words. Going downward it is the same, with one more layer: the big one, the second, the youngest. Called by order. The word used for the person you cherish most in the world is the order in which they were born, and nobody finds that odd.

So the place where a name is least said is the closest place. A person addressed politely by name outside

walks in the door and becomes the second one.

When the years of being called only by a position word run long, a household can be the last to learn what that person was besides the position, and that is why it is common to hear, for the first time after a parent dies, a different story about them.

This is not a call to change it. No household calls its father by his name, and that would not be better.

Only: the person inside that position word is larger than the position, and the larger part is what the word written above points at. A house is the likeliest place to forget it.

◆ Can Expectation Be Subtracted

Here is a question I never finished. Is love without expectation possible?

To stop measuring it seems you would have to set expectation down, and I do not know whether a state with all expectation set down is love. Wanting

nothing has the same shape as indifference. It is hard to call a parent loving who says it does not matter what becomes of their child. So expectation has to be there, and with expectation a ruler follows, and with a ruler there is measuring. I have not yet met anyone who knows where to cut it. I am as far as holding the question.

One guess can be set down. Subtracting expectation is hard, and **asking about something besides expectation** looks worth trying. Not *do not ask about the score*. Do not ask only about the score. That much can be attempted.

And the word used in this chapter only reaches so far. With it you can point at where the shaving happens; what to do from there does not come out of it. So the section below is written without it.

◆ Today

Go home today and **do not ask one family member what they did today**. Do not ask how the day was, do not ask whether they finished. Ask something entirely useless instead. What was funniest today. What they keep thinking about lately.

Try it and it is strangely awkward. The awkwardness tells you what kind of talk has been going through that house.

◆ Where This Chapter Comes From

There are no outside facts in this chapter. Only what the author saw and thought while standing there, and the scene in the middle is its only case.

One thing to record. This book set out to use the word *dignity* sparingly, and this is the only chapter that uses it. It is used here to show one thing: that the word has force outside and nowhere to be applied inside a house. The question that follows — then where does the worth come from — is not

handled here. That belongs to the last chapter, and there the word is not used again.

There is one place in this chapter that was corrected while writing. I had *did you take your medicine* down as an example of a measuring question, and on its own that was wrong, because it left out that the sentence is also a way of saying I love you.

Correcting it deepened the chapter by a layer, and the reason I did not write it that way to begin with is that I was looking at the sentence from outside.

I went looking for research on conversation inside families. Figures circulate along the lines of what percentage of what parents say to children concerns grades, and where and how it was measured never came out. One number would have made this chapter look solid, and a number that cannot be supported was not used.

This chapter was inside the house. The next one is where the same thing has become an institution

outside it. There, the person measuring does not feel bad. It is the job.

13 · Where the Review Form Folds a Person

◆ 20 · 70 · 10

In the 1980s a large American manufacturer used a method that sorted employees into three lumps. The top twenty percent were the strong ones, the middle seventy were the serviceable ones, the bottom ten were the ones to let go, and the proportions were fixed first so that they added to a hundred, and people were fitted into the proportions.

The last chapter was inside the house. At home the person measuring feels bad. Here they do not. It is their job, and not doing it means not having done the job.

◆ You Know on Your First Day

A software company used a similar method for a long time, and in 2012 a magazine ran a long piece on that company's previous decade. In it is a line from a developer who had worked there.

If you're on a team of ten people, you walk in the first day knowing that, no matter how good everyone is, two people are going to get a great review, seven are going to get mediocre reviews, and one is going to get a terrible review.

The first day. Before anything has been done at all.

◆ The Boxes Exist Before the Work

What that line shows is the shape of evaluation. It looks like something scored after the work is seen; it is a procedure in which the boxes come first and people are put into them. **It is not measuring. It is dividing.**

Which is why the same person's rating changes when they change teams. The work is identical and depending on who is sitting nearby they land in a lower box or a higher one. What the rating tells you, then, is not the person but the composition of the team, and the person receives it as news about themselves.

If one of ten has to go in the bottom box, then on a team where all ten are good, one still goes to the bottom, which means a seat comes round every year in which someone who has done nothing wrong becomes the person who did.

◆ Switched Off in Six Words

In November 2013 that software company dropped the method. An internal email is reported to have said this.

No more curve.

And a paragraph later.

And no more ratings.

No curve and no ratings. A machine that had been turning for close to thirty years was switched off in six words. Several other large companies followed.

It is good news, and this chapter cannot end there. Ending on an institution being reformed makes it a business story. The side this chapter wants to look at is the people who had been inside those boxes, and their several years cannot be returned by an email.

I have almost never written a rating on a review form. I have received them several times. What I received were not numbers. They were words.

Naive. Does not know how the world works.
Kind.

None of the three is an insult. The first two are not compliments either. They are words you are not sure which box to put in, and when you receive one you quickly learn that the vague word is itself the box, and in chapter three I wrote that the thing my resume has no box for is purity. **The same thing gets written down here as a fault.** On one side there is no box to write it in and on the other side there is. The side with the box always wins.

I would still like to live purely.

◆ What It Means to Be Folded

A review form has about ten boxes on it. Those boxes do not so much cut a person as fold them. Folded, they fit, and once they fit, the folded side is not visible. Unlike cutting, nothing is gone — and to the person reading the form it is exactly the same as gone.

What is on the folded side? Someone who took every question the new arrival had. Someone who said the thing nobody in the meeting wanted to say. Someone who took on the work that produces no number and left it tidy for whoever came next. It fits no box, so it is not written.

It is strange that the side not written down is the side used for seeing people as people.

◆ So What Do You Raise and Lower With

From here on I am empty-handed.

Abolish evaluation and what do you raise and lower with? You cannot not raise and lower. Salaries have to be set and positions have to be set, and for that someone has to write down who did more. The companies that switched off the curve removed the ratings and kept on raising and lowering. So it may be that the ruler did not disappear; it went somewhere you cannot see. Whether an invisible

ruler is better than a visible one, I do not know. A written grade can at least be argued with.

◆ In Short

What evaluation looks like it does	What it actually does
Measures that person's work	Fits people into fixed proportions
The better person goes higher	The box turns on who is sitting nearby
What is written is the person	The unwritten side is folded out of sight

◆ Today

Think of one person you work with and find one thing **their review form has no box for**, and tell them. Not praise — you have to pick something unwritten. One thing with no bearing on the grade they got this year.

The answer that comes back most often is that they did not know they were doing it. Work that does not get recorded is not being counted by the person doing it either.

◆ Where This Chapter Comes From

The developer's line is from Kurt Eichenwald's article in *Vanity Fair*, August 2012, and the two sentences ending ratings are from an internal email sent by that company's head of HR in November 2013. The 20 · 70 · 10 method is generally attributed to General Electric in the 1980s.

Both quotations are at the level of public sources cross-read against one another. I could open neither the magazine original nor the full email. They carry quotation marks, so the originals should be seen before publication.

Only one date is used. The years in which other companies dropped it differ across sources, so they

are handled as *followed*, and company names appear only where they are necessary, because if this chapter reads as a story about one company, the reader concludes it is not about theirs.

The next chapter is about strangers. At home and at work we know the person and measure them; the people we pass in a day go by without even that.

14 · The People We Pass in a Day

◆ Back to the Same Spot a Week Later

In 1972 a psychologist tried this. In the morning rush he went to a commuter rail platform and photographed the people waiting. A week later he came back to the same platform at the same hour and handed the photographs to the people standing there.

He asked two things. Is there a face here you recognize? Have you ever spoken to any of them?

About eighty-nine percent of the people who received a photograph recognized at least one person. The average was four. Almost none of them had ever spoken.

◆ Recognized and Not Known

The psychologist gave this relationship a name. The familiar stranger.

Someone you see every day in the same spot, whose face you know, whose absence yesterday you would have noticed, and to whom you have never once spoken. It runs both ways. The people on that platform knew about four faces, and those four knew them in exactly the same way.

That is not being strangers and not being acquainted. So what is it? It is knowing the role only. That person is the one who takes that car every day, and to them I am the one who stands in that spot every day, and most of the people we meet in a day are in this relationship.

◆ Thirty-Two Years Later, Again

In 2004 other researchers used the same method again. This time not on a platform but in plazas, at bus stops, on walking routes. Seventy-seven point eight percent recognized at least one person, and the number recognized averaged about three out of sixty-three.

There is a sentence that wants to be written here. It dropped from 89 to 77.8, so people recognize each other less than they used to. I will not write it.

The places measured are different. The first is people who stand on the same platform at the same hour every day; the second is people crossing a plaza, and someone who stands in the same spot daily and someone passing through were always going to come out differently. Line the two numbers up and blame the intervening years, and from that point the mismeasuring is ours.

They are at the school and at the security desk and in the restaurant. People who do their work without

comment. I barely know any of their names. There was a day when one of them came into view as a person. It was not because I spoke to them. **It was watching them help without a word.** Nobody had asked and nobody was making anything of it. They did it and went on.

Two things changed afterward. I greet them in passing. And when there is something small to share, I share it. It is not a dramatic change. Only that I did neither before.

◆ You Notice When They Are Not There

This relationship has one property. Present, they are invisible; absent, they are visible.

When someone who was always in that spot is not there one day, you notice at once. A different person at the security desk and you know. The one at the shop you always go to is not there and you know.

You do not know their name and you have barely exchanged words and you know they are gone.

So it is not that we do not know them. We know, and do not know that we know. In Part Two I wrote that a person shows where usefulness has been taken away; here, the person shows where the person has been taken away. There are several a day who only become visible by being missing.

◆ What the Fare Card Drew

There is one more study, from 2013. Using the transit card records of a city of about five million, it linked who had been on the same bus at the same time as whom. Nobody was asked anything; only the records were read.

Three things came out. Repeated encounters were regular, and therefore predictable. People who met that way did not split into small clusters; the longer it went, the more densely they linked, and the result is a

very large network laid across the whole city, and not one person inside it could feel that it was there.

People we pass only as roles are not nothing to us. They are an invisible something. It is already laid down, and we simply do not know it.

◆ See Everyone as a Person and the Day Does Not Finish

Here is the unresolved part. Try to see every person you pass in a day as a person and the day does not finish.

There are a hundred people in a subway car. Seeing a hundred people one at a time cannot be done. So we see them as roles, and seeing them as roles is not rudeness; without folding them away like that you could not cross the street. Then how far do you fold and from where do you unfold? Unfold the people you see daily and fold the ones you see once? Decide it that way and the chapter ends up saying that only

people you see often are people, and that cannot be right. I did not finish this arithmetic.

◆ Today

Say **one more thing** to someone you only meet as a role. Not a greeting — one more thing after it. That it is cold, that the queue was long earlier, that you wondered whether they are always here at this hour. One is enough.

The answer may be short or may not come. Even so, once that one sentence has passed, there is a line between you that was not there before. The next time they are missing, this time you will notice.

◆ Where This Chapter Comes From

The 1972 work is Stanley Milgram's "The Familiar Stranger: An Aspect of Urban Anonymity," first published in a division newsletter of the American

Psychological Association and reprinted in his 1977 book. The 2004 work is by Paulos and Goodman of Intel Research Berkeley, and the 2013 transit-card study is by Sun, Axhausen and others in *PNAS*.

I could open none of the three originals. This is public sources cross-read against one another.

Two notes. First, the 1972 figure appears as both 89 and 89.5 percent depending on the source, so it is written as about eighty-nine percent. Second, **the 1972 and 2004 numbers are not placed side by side**, because the places surveyed differ. The reason is written into the body of this chapter because I saw them placed side by side in several other pieces of writing.

Part Four ends here. We looked at how we measure people at home, at work, and on the street. Part Five is what happens when one more thing enters those three places.

Part Five • After the Machines

For fourteen chapters this book has not once talked about machines. Here it does, for the first time.

There is a reason for that order. Bring machines in early and everything after reads as being about machines, and measuring people was going on long before any machine, and what Part One looked at was a diary from 1785. The machine only used the existing ruler faster.

So Part Five does not ask what a machine can do. It asks what happens to a person who made usefulness the reason they hold their place. Three chapters. The place where competing means losing, the place that

empties after that person leaves, and the last question.

And this part stops at three. Write more and this becomes a book about machines, and this is not that book. That book exists separately.

15 · Compete on Usefulness and You Lose

◆ The Loser Is Decided in Advance

The conclusion first. A person who has made usefulness the reason they hold their place gives that place up on the day something more useful appears, and it is not the kind of contest you survive by trying harder. The moment you agree to compete, the loser is decided.

For fourteen chapters this book has not once talked about machines. Here it does for the first time. But what this chapter looks at is less what the machine did than the person who was standing there.

◆ It Was Not a Small Job

You picked up a telephone and a person answered.
An operator pushed a plug in and joined two houses.

In the 1920s the largest employer in America was the telephone company, and more than half its workforce were operators. And a calculation from 1930 survives.

If the present rate of growth continues, within a few years we will need most of that population.

That population is the young women of American cities. To connect every call you would have to sit nearly all of them at a switchboard. That is how large the job was.

◆ Twenty Years

Between 1920 and 1940 the company converted more than half of the American network to dial, and when a city converted, the number of the next cohort

entering as operators in that city fell immediately, and stayed down. Fifty to eighty percent.

A job the whole country nearly needed was gone in twenty years.

The scope of the figures should be narrowed here. What the study counted was young, white, American-born women. Write it as simply *women* and I am the one who widened it.

◆ The Statistics Are Fine and the People Are Not

Then comes the part that is this chapter. Split what happened after the job disappeared into two rows and the result reads in opposite directions.

Who	What happened
The people doing the job at the time	Less likely to be in that job ten years later, more likely not working at all, and lower paid when working

Who	What happened
The next cohort	Total employment did not fall. They went into clerical and service work, and into jobs that had not existed

The top row is people and the bottom row is statistics.

When someone says it turned out fine in the end, they are reading the bottom row, and the person who was in the top row is invisible inside that statistic. The bottom row is also true. That it was of no use whatever to the person in the top row is also true.

◆ Size Is Not Protection

One thing can be set down here. That the job was large did not protect the job.

It was the job the most people in the country did. Without it the telephone did not work. And it went. *So this work employs so many people that it will be*

fine is not grounds for anything. Size is not protection.

And not one of the people doing it was pushed out for being bad at it. The operators were good at it. Which returns us to saying that it was not a contest being good could win.

◆ Chapter Seven Is Here

Part Two had four people, and the last of them was someone skilled with nowhere to use it. That chapter contains no case material from outside. It is not that none could be found. That chapter has to stand on what the author saw.

The case is here.

Think of an operator in a city converted to dial. Her hands are the same. She can still take a number and push a plug, probably faster than anyone else in that

city. What disappeared is not the skill. It is the place to use it.

In chapter seven this was called having nowhere to use it. *Nowhere to use it* sounds like the person shrank, and nothing on the person's side shrank at all. A hole closed on the world's side. The same person was indispensable yesterday and unnecessary today, having done nothing in between.

◆ Whose Story Are We Telling

Here is the knot I could not tie. I tried several times to put the top row and the bottom row into one sentence, and each time one of them got erased.

Read only the top row and it becomes writing in which the world only gets worse. Read only the bottom row and it becomes writing in which there is nothing to worry about. Both are false. It seems that people having this conversation would need to settle

first whose story they are telling, and I could not find a way to settle it.

I should put down my own case, which sits slightly askew to this chapter. I will leave it askew.

I cannot easily think of a place I held because I was better at it than others. There is one thing I have done for a long time: speaking to people. Greeting them and paying small attention. **That work has still not disappeared.**

Thinking about why it has not, the answer is a little deflating. **Because it was never a contest.** There is no ranking in it, and if someone better at greeting people arrives, the greeting I was doing does not become unnecessary, because the receiving side is different.

This chapter is about losing when you compete on usefulness, and here is its reverse side. **Work that cannot be competed over cannot be taken away either.** That kind of work pays badly, and the reason

it pays badly is the same as the reason it cannot be taken.

◆ In Short

What people say	Which row it reads
Just as many new jobs appeared	The bottom row — the next cohort
What became of those people	The top row — the ones doing it
A job that big will not disappear	Neither row supports it

◆ Today

Write one line on paper. One place you are currently holding because you are better at it than others. A job, a task at home, a share in some group.

Then ask once. If something better than me arrives, what happens to this place? It is normal for no

answer to come. The answer is the next two chapters.

◆ Where This Chapter Comes From

Feigenbaum and Gross, "Answering the Call of Automation: How the Labor Market Adjusted to Mechanizing Telephone Operation," *Quarterly Journal of Economics* 139, no. 3 (2024), 1879–1939. It uses data from three thousand American cities.

I could not open the original. This is public sources cross-read against one another, and the figures and citation are confirmed at that level.

One quotation is flagged. The 1930 calculation is something the paper itself drew from a contemporary source. That makes it a quotation of a quotation, and since it carries quotation marks, someone should go to where it was first printed before publication.

The next chapter is the place the job left behind. This chapter looked at where the people went; the next looks at what remains where the people were.

16 · The Place That Empties Out

◆ Seven Households in Ten

There is a record from 1933 of a village in Austria. The village factory closed and most of the village lost its work. Three researchers moved in and lived there and wrote it down.

In that record there is a number. Seventy percent of the village's households were in a state the study called drifting along.

Drifting is the study's own word. It does not mean despair. It means being there with no plan and no expectation, doing only barely what has to be done.

◆ Time Collapsed Before the Money Ran Out

What catches first in that record is not the money.

The sense of time collapsed first. With the frame of a day and a week gone, people could not build time for themselves. If there is no reason to get up in the morning the hour of getting up scatters, and once it scatters the day mashes into one lump, and then what you can do shrinks. It is unlike not being able to do something for lack of money. It is not being able to start.

And what they wanted shrank. Even the few chances that remained went unused. That is the most frightening line. The willingness to use a chance disappears after the chances do.

◆ There Is No Money Among the Five

One of those researchers set out a summary forty-nine years later: five things work had been quietly giving people.

One	The frame of a day and a week
Two	Activity that makes you act
Three	People outside the family
Four	A shared purpose — the sense of being useful to someone
Five	A position and a name

There is no money among the five.

That losing work means losing money is known to everyone. What nobody counts as lost is those five. And while the work is going on you do not even know you are receiving them. Receiving without knowing, when it is cut you are left empty without knowing what was cut.

Look at the fourth line again. The sense of being useful to someone. This book has spent fourteen

chapters saying not to measure people by usefulness, and there it is inside what a person out of work misses, and the contradiction is written down rather than cleared away.

I was out of work once. Six months.

On weekday afternoons I was at home or at the library. I went to the library partly because there were books to read and partly because I needed somewhere to be at that hour, and leave in the morning and come back in the evening and the day has a shape. There were days I went in order to make the shape.

If I had to write down one thing that disappeared in those six months, it is not money. **My own self-importance disappeared.** The stubbornness went with it. That is not a loss to regret. It was better gone.

Then what was it that I missed? Which of the five it was, I have still not managed to name. There was

definitely one, and it would not come into focus then and it does not now.

◆ Looking Into That Contradiction

Having decided not to clear it away, look once more. The word usefulness is being used for two things.

The usefulness used for measuring and the sense of being used are different things. The first makes a ranking: it produces where you come in the order. The second makes no ranking. There is no ranking in putting a meal on a table, and none in the feeling that somebody is waiting for you.

So what this book was trying to say cannot be *throw usefulness away*. Throw it away and the fourth of those five goes with it. **Only the ranking-making kind is being set down.**

Whether the two can be cleanly separated, though, I do not know. The sense of being needed turns into a

ranking as soon as you start counting it, and the moment it becomes how many people need you it is the same ruler again, and where that crossing happens is something I could not put my finger on.

◆ Ninety Years Later, Another Country

There is a study from 2019. It looked at American regions where manufacturing declined between 1990 and 2014 and recorded what moved together on the side of young men.

Employment and income fell. The share doing nothing rose. Early deaths rose. Marriage fell and children fell.

Care is needed here. What the study said reaches as far as these things moving together. Writing it so that it reads as *no work means no marriage* is me going a step further. And this list is from looking at young men.

◆ The Two Places Are Not Joined

In one village in 1933 and one region in 2014, the same place is empty. Writing it that far is what can be done.

Writing that nothing changed in ninety years is not allowed. The countries differ, the times differ, the methods differ. Moving into a village and writing it down and cross-reading regional statistics are not the same kind of material. Chapters nine and fourteen passed the same place, and this is the third.

The same shape was seen separately in different places. That far. That is heavy enough on its own.

◆ If You Make Up the Income, Is the Rest Made Up

The unresolved part of this chapter is made by that list of five.

If you make up the lost income for someone out of work, is the rest made up? Does money bring back the frame of a day? Does it bring back people outside the family? A position and a name? It does not seem so, and I also have no material saying it does not. Reading this as *do not give money* would be worse. Money should be given, and whether money alone fills those five I do not know. I leave the question here and go to the next chapter.

◆ In Short

What we know is lost with work	What is lost alongside and not counted
Income	The frame of a day and a week
	Activity that makes you act
	People outside the family

What we know is lost with
work

What is lost alongside and not
counted

The sense of being useful
to someone

A position and a name

◆ Today

Write down **three things besides money** that you get from your work. Choose from the five above or write something not on the list. Three lines on one sheet.

Written out, those three are what you are currently receiving. Counting what you were receiving without knowing is today's job, and a person who has counted them can recognize their absence in someone else.

◆ Where This Chapter Comes From

The 1933 record is the Marienthal study by Jahoda, Lazarsfeld and Zeisel. The list of five is Jahoda's own summary from 1982. The 2019 study is Autor, Dorn and Hanson in *American Economic Review: Insights* 1, no. 2, pages 161 – 178.

I could open none of the three originals. This is public sources cross-read against one another. Someone should obtain a copy of the Marienthal book before publication, and check at the same time whether a translation exists.

Three things were cut. They are commonly quoted alongside that village — that people's walking speed slowed, that library borrowing fell, that organizations disappeared. None of the three could be supported. Putting them in would make this chapter far more vivid, which is exactly why they are more dangerous. They were cut whole.

Only the three above were used. The sense of time, the shrinking of expectation, and the seventy percent.

17 · Then Where Does the Worth Come From

◆ What Was Asked Sixteen Chapters Ago

This book began with one question.

If a person's worth comes from usefulness, does a person with no usefulness left have no worth?

Sixteen chapters have gone by. Part One looked at when we began counting people, Part Two at four people standing where usefulness had been taken away, Part Three set down four things to do, Part Four looked at how we measure at home and at work and on the street, and Part Five at the place where competing means losing and the place that empties out.

So now the question is turned over.

If it does not come from usefulness, then where does the worth come from?

◆ No Answer Is Written Here

If I could write an answer in this spot, this book would have been much shorter. One page would have done. I cannot produce the grounds. And I think not being able to is correct. Writing down the answers that come to mind, there are three, and all three have a hole at the end of them.

There is the side that says a person has worth because they are a person, and then you have to ask again why being a person constitutes worth, and from there it circles.

There is the side that says a person has worth because someone gave it, and then the giver has to be

accepted first, and for a person who has accepted that, this question is already finished.

There is the side that says a person has worth because we have agreed to treat each other that way. Then the worth disappears on the day we agree otherwise. What Part One looked at is a place where that happened.

I wrote all three down and looked at them a long while and could not take one more step in any direction.

It was the day my wife had surgery.

I stayed up through the night on a chair in the corridor outside the operating room. It must have been about seven hours.

There was nothing in my hands. Nothing to hold and nothing I could do. I prayed there for the lives of my wife and the child. There was nothing else I knew how to do.

In that place I was of no use at all. It was a place where the surgery did not go better for my being there and nothing would have been different had I not been, and still I did not leave. The thought of leaving did not arise.

I think I was standing in front of this book's question that night. I did not know it at the time.

◆ There Is No Answer in This Book

But it is not as though sixteen chapters did nothing.

Each chapter had one *Today* at the end of it. Saying a name once more. Counting the places you wanted to cut in. Having a conversation without asking about work. Swallowing the solution. Not asking a family member what they did today. Finding something a coworker's review form has no box for and saying it. Saying one more thing to someone you meet only as a role. Writing down three things besides money.

All sixteen are small. Not one of them is an answer. And a person who has done all sixteen comes to see the person in front of them differently. It happens without the grounds ever being produced.

This is all I know. I do not know where the worth comes from, and **even not knowing, it is possible to treat someone that way.** It may be that the order of the two is the reverse of what I assumed. Knowing and then treating people accordingly looks like the sequence, and it may be that the person who has treated people that way is the one who comes to know later.

This is the end of the book, and I think stopping here is right. Write more and from the next line on it is a sermon.

◆ Where This Chapter Comes From

There are no outside facts in this chapter. No case material either. It stands on what the sixteen chapters

brought. This is the only chapter with no *Today*.
Sixteen have one and only this one does not. It is not
a space left blank for lack of anything to put there.
The question below takes that place.

◆ Last

There is a person beside you right now. There will be
days when that person is of no use to you at all.

Where does that person's worth come from?

How to See a Person ·